

2007 Intern Review

Manager Review

Jonathan Daniel Micklos

Performance Review: 04/01/2007 - 03/31/2008

Reviewer: Kevin Maher

Role: Manager

Status: Completed

Manager: Kevin Maher

Performance Goals

New Style Alerts - Event Provider

New Style Alerts will allow customers to subscribe for notifications of new style availability. This system will be extensible to myriad new style use cases under amazon.com. It has three tiers, a customer facing subscription tier, a middle notification generation tier and an email creation and emission tier. Primarily, it will be implemented for New Style Alerts in Endless.com. The scope of Jon's work is to design and implement a scalable middle tier which includes event provider, its associated database work, configurations if any & deployment of the same in all locales. In addition, work with the customer facing team by helping to design the appropriate subscription schema in GSS and delivery channel. Lastly, document "how, what, why" of New Style Alerts and the event provider to enable extending the new product alerts to Amazon and other websites that might use different delivery channels (RTE, Correios, etc).

Employee Summary:

New Style Alerts provides customers with notifications of new styles they may want to purchase. For Endless.com, this is another avenue for which to advertise to customers and bring in purchase traffic. My design is extensible to many use cases for all types of product groups within amazon.com. This will cut down on development time by simply requiring a configuration file for AWS E-Commerce based events.

The New Style Alerts for Endless.com use case was written by members of the Endless.com team such as Douglas Irvine, Jeremy Fan and Sandra Cheng as well as members of the ENS team Sulabh Gigras and Devraj Varadhan. I felt it would be advantageous to design the implementation in a more general sense. My redesign facilitated event creation for any data from AWS E-Commerce.

I most directly worked with Sulabh and the members of the Endless.com team. For any problem I would have, I would seek help from not only Sulabh, but also members of the Endless team (such as Jeremy Fan) and members of other teams (brazil-build, etc). I would likewise seek multiple solutions at the same time until a viable option would present itself.

I have delivered the ENSAWSECommerceEventProvider, the SQL for the creation of appropriate tables in ENS, the brazil-config for New Style Events in Endless.com and the associated documentation for the whole system. The Oracle rules for notification generation still need work. The Endless.com team needs to update GSS and create the frontend for subscription management in Endless.com. Also, the Endless.com team needs to create the appropriate email templates for email delivery in ENS.

Manager Summary:

Sulabh's summary:

The New style alerts for Endless provides ability for customers to subscribe for notifications of new styles becoming available within a brand and department. These alerts are being developed on top of the Event Notification System platform. The project involved writing an Event provider which would not only provide new style alert events for Endless but also should be easily configurable to provide new product alerts for any category in Amazon or any other marketplace. Jon was able to address the challenges effectively listed below and completed the project on time. Jon & I initially brainstormed for a couple of days about the design before we came up with a high level design for the endless new style alert. From there, Jon was able to run with the design ideas with minimal involvement from my side. Some of the major roadblocks were:

- Understanding the ENS framework: This he was able to do very comfortably by going through the technical specs and with some help from me. He grasped the idea very quickly and was able to easily identify the different components and also understand what it takes to implement a new use case in ENS.
- Coming up with an extensible design for the event provider: He was able to come up with a good design which he was able to test for a couple of use cases too including new book by author and new cd by artist alerts.
- Resolving issues with AWS and Endless: The event provider uses AWS to make search queries and get the new style events. He was able to work with the AWS team and endless team to figure out exactly what queries need to be made and how. He also was able to use Remote Product Aggregator and Catalog when problems came up with AWS. The biggest positive was the maturity and patience with which he handled any setbacks or unexpected edge-cases and then incorporated them properly into his design.

He was also to test the event provider thoroughly also did thorough documentation for both of his projects. Overall it was a superb work by Jon on all counts

Notify Me When Available Block List

The Notify Me When Available Block List provides a means by which ASINs can be blocked from displaying the “Notify Me When Available” button. This system will be integrated with the already working ENS Dashboard for administration purposes. It will likewise have a database component and means by which that database component will translate into blocked ASINs on the website. I will be working with Sulabh Gigras (who has prior knowledge of the ENS Dashboard) so that I can write the front end logic. I will also be implementing MySQL tables for ASIN Block List storage. From this MySQL database, a BDB must be created as a means for which to communicate the updated block list. I will create the logic for the creation of this BDB. The limitations of this system will be the capacity limitations of MySQL and BDB. I will also create the appropriate documentation for my work.

Employee Summary:

The Notify Me When Available Block List will provide Amazon.com with the ability to block the appearance of a future release of certain recently banned products. A good example is the OJ Simpson book “If I Did It.” Despite not being sold, it was implied on amazon.com that the book would be sold in the future. With this block list, trust is built with the customer as products which are banned will no longer have the notify me when available. Likewise, this helps Amazon.com with its corporate image. This project is not specific to the Amazon.com marketplace and can be used for any marketplace which utilizes the “Notify Me When Available” button.

This use case was given to me for my first project here at Amazon.com. For the design, I worked with Sulabh Gigras. I would also seek out his help for problems I could not immediately solve within a reasonable amount of time. As with my other project, I would also seek help from other teams within Amazon.com if applicable.

The components which I successfully designed and implemented include the Web Administration front end, the SQL Tables, and the logic for the BDB creator. The logic which reads the BDB and prevents the “Notify Me When Available” button from popping up still needs to be put in place.

Manager Summary:

Sulabh's summary:

The notify me when available Block List is an important tool which allows us to block ASIN's from displaying the EMWA sign up option on the website in a real time fashion. The components involved in this project were: Web UI in dashboard for managing block list, SQL tables in dashboard database, BDB with block lists ASINs, logic for BDB creation from the dashboard database, putting everything in brazil and apollo and last but not least automating the entire process by scheduling a daily build through HAM. Jon was able to complete all the components in time and with very minimal help from me. We initially worked on the design together but after that he was totally self-sufficient and needed very little help from me. The first thing that impressed was his technical competence. Ramping up in Amazon environment provides a tough challenge for any new intern or SDE and I was expecting to spend a lot of time in the first couple of weeks with him but he was able to get through the boot camp and learn about Amazon tools like brazil and Apollo in less than a week with very minimal help from me. He has a very good understanding of industry tools for java development, databases, IDE's along with good coding habits. He was able to start coding in Java for the BDB creator package in about a week less than I was expecting him to. A number of problems were faced by him along the way in getting his Java code to work but each time he was able to solve it himself using his previous knowledge. The second thing that impressed me is how proactive Jon is and willingness to look at multiple sources to solve a problem rather than waiting for myself or anyone to spoon-feed the solution. This was evident multiple times during the project: when he was facing apollo build issues with his java package for BDB creator he talked to Brazil and apollo team directly to resolve the issue, when he was having trouble setting up the ham orchestration for block list bdb he talked to the ham team directly etc. Overall my involvement during the coding phase was minimal and was limited to code/design reviews and getting daily status updates. The end product was very good and meets the Amazon quality bar and we even used his code for automating one of our other projects.

Identify Strengths

Has Operational & Customer Focus

SDEs focus on making things better for customers by quickly and thoroughly resolving defects; always research and seek the root cause to solve problems; understand the business context and impact of their work and consider scaling issues; provide excellent on-call customer support; are advocates for customers - both internal and external.

Employee Summary:

My career focus is not just technology. Rather, the reason why I enjoy technology (more specifically software development) is because it offers a dynamic means for which to create value propositions. I appreciate and strive to implement technologies which do not simply exist for the sake of technology but which bring a better experience for customers and/or those in the company. My design of New Style Alerts will allow any data in AWS E-Commerce to be used to create events in a seamless manner, not just New Style Events for Endless.com. This translates into greater purchase flow as customers will be conveniently provided with news of products which they are interested in purchasing.

Manager Summary:

Agreed

Ownership

* We want employees at all levels to have a long-term, vested interest in the success of Amazon.com.

- * If we want employees who think and work like owners, they need to be owners.
- * Owners plead passionately for their positions and champion ideas they believe will benefit the business.
- * Owners are empowered to respectfully challenge the decisions and directives of other owners, especially when those decisions and directives conflict with our mission and values.
- * Owners meet commitments to their fellow owners.
- * Owners build healthy independence over time.
- * Owners think long-term.

Employee Summary:

I design with the understanding that my systems may be used in the most strenuous and critical of environments and built upon well after I have stopped development. With this in mind, I always develop and test technologies so that they handle edge case scenarios. I likewise strive to develop technologies with the intent of further development. In conjunction with my operational focus, I work to build things which seamlessly work for yet unknown use cases, work under the most rare circumstances, while not overly complicating or hindering the needs of the original requirements. Most importantly, when I am wrong or something of mine has broken, I am quick to rectify the situation.

Manager Summary:

Agreed

Identify Areas for Improvement

Knows and Uses Available Tools

Most of the delays which I have experienced over the course of my projects have been due to issues with the tools I was using. There were occasions where certain tools were not performing in the manner in which I had inferred from what I was told. There were also occasions where certain tools may require an obtuse command or action to remedy a problem. An example of this would include updating the package version cache in brazil. Despite these problems, I have worked to understand the multitude of different tools that I use with my projects here at Amazon.com.

Employee Summary:

Most of the delays which I have experienced over the course of my projects have been due to issues with the tools I was using. There were occasions where certain tools were not performing in the manner in which I had inferred from what I was told. There were also occasions where certain tools may require an obtuse command or action to remedy a problem. An example of this would include updating the package version cache in brazil. Despite these problems, I have worked to understand the multitude of different tools that I use with my projects here at Amazon.com.

Manager Summary:

Agreed

Additional Comments

Employee Summary:

Manager Summary:

Employee Summary:

Manager Summary: